

AIRBORNE FORCES UNIFORM AND KIT

World War II witnessed an expansion in the use of parachute-equipped troops. The strength of airborne formations was their strategic mobility, but once the paratrooper landed he became a heavily burdened infantryman, lacking both tactical mobility and firepower. Miniaturized motorcycles and simple folding bicycles were used to improve his capability but had limited success. Light mortars and shoulder-launched anti-tank weapons, used by conventional infantry, provided the paratrooper with portable “artillery”.

► M1942 JUMP JACKET

Date 1942

Origin US

Material Cotton poplin

The olive green jacket was spray-painted at unit level. The uniform was sprayed while on the body, the soldier covering his head with a cardboard box. This left the collar untouched by paint.

▼ JUMP BOOTS

Date 1942

Origin US

Material Leather, rubber, canvas

The coveted status symbol of the US airborne forces, jump boots were designed for parachuting safety, with reinforced toecaps, internal ankle supports, and a bevelled heel to prevent the heel snagging on the uneven aircraft floor.



◀ M2 PARATROOPER HELMET

Date 1942

Origin US

Material Steel

The airborne helmet had a D-ring chinstrap holder and a spray-paint camouflage, applied by its owner. The “Gingerbread Man” was the emblem of the 509th Airborne Battalion.



Pockets double-stitched to prevent ripping when carrying grenades

▼ M1A1 CARBINE

Date 1942

Origin US

Weight 2.36kg (5¼lb)

Barrel 45.7cm (18in)

Calibre .3in

The M1 Carbine had already proved to be popular with soldiers who needed a lightweight weapon. For airborne forces, this special M1A1 variant was produced, complete with a folding stock for use during parachute drops.

